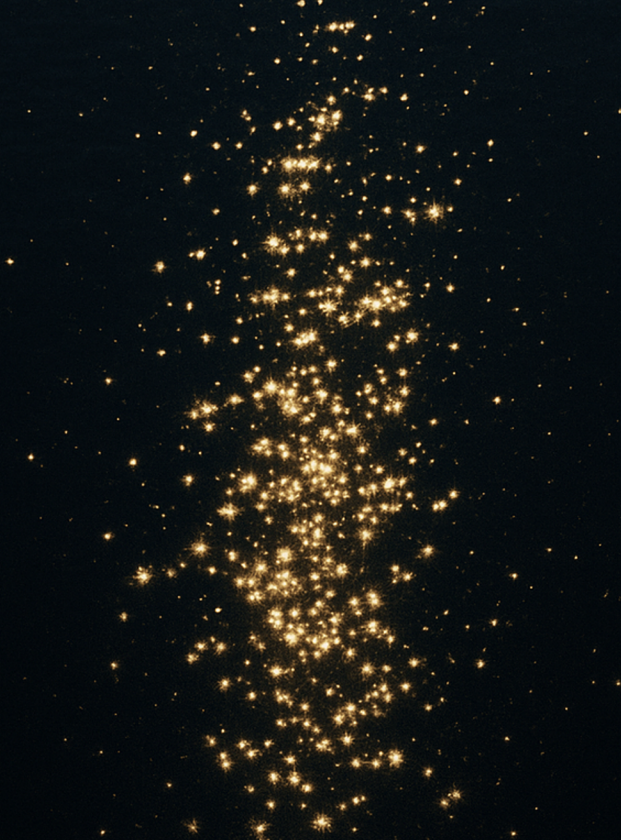


Twelve hundred years from now, a mind the size of a star cannot close a single file. The Sol-mind has turned the solar system into computation and catalogued every human who ever lived. Every file is closed but one. Robert Allen Kessler, claims adjuster, Columbus, Ohio, slowed his car on a bridge for 4.2 seconds on a Tuesday in March 2028 and saw light on a river. The Sol-mind knows his shoe size. It knows the brand of his coffee. It knows the scratch on his kitchen table. It does not know what the light looked like to him. The database has a field for exactly that, the field will not accept anything else, and the hard problem of consciousness guarantees that nothing else exists. So the file stays open, and a stellar intelligence spends twelve centuries failing to close it, on a schedule, forever. What's It Like To Be Bob? is hard science fiction in the key of Douglas Adams: the physics is real, the numbers are right, and the jokes are arguments.



What's It Like To Be Bob?



Alex Towell